Much of this is aimed squarely at China, which is identified in the act as the primary threat to the liberal order that has allowed for Asia's peaceful development since 1945. Such funding represents a material commitment to Trump's call for a "free and open Indo-Pacific" far beyond what supported Barack Obama's pivot. Yet without a comprehensive strategy to maintain the balance of power in Asia, the billions of dollars will be ineffective in responding to China's security, economic, and cyber challenges.[46]

As for North Korea, a quarter century of US diplomacy has failed in its primary goal of preventing Pyongyang from developing a nuclear arsenal and the ballistic missile force to deliver it. Short of war or the deposition of the Kim family regime, there is little likelihood of North Korea fully denuclearizing, even if the US offered a complete withdrawal of forces from the peninsula. While Trump's gambit of trying to obtain denuclearization through a combination of threats, sanctions, and negotiations should be given time to work, the bulk of US strategy toward Pyongyang should shift to considering how to deter and contain a nuclear North Korea, as well as take advantage of any opportunities to weaken the Kim regime. This will have to include articulating clear and credible red lines beyond which American retaliation will occur. Sustaining our allies to the fullest extent possible and making further efforts to force Japan and South Korea to work more closely together, despite worsening relations over trade and history issues, should also be a priority.

The role of America's allies is indispensable to helping maintain a favorable balance of power in the region. Japan remains Washington's most steadfast ally, and continuing to deepen alliance cooperation, as well as provide defense materials, should be a priority. While relations with South Korea are being tested by Seoul's current outreach to Pyongyang, Washington's credibility throughout the region rests in no small part on its willingness to reaffirm its commitment to South Korea's defense. Until Seoul determines that it desires a different relationship with Washington, US promises should be kept, and all possible assistance should be given to South Korea to maintain a robust